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“Life Is a State of Mind”

In the 1979 award-winning satire *Being There*, the comedy of the film is present in scenes where only the audience understands the miscommunication happening between the main character, Chance, and the people he interacts with. In the film, the gardener of a dying old man, Chance, has seemingly never been allowed to leave the house, read books, or learn how to write. His only form of interaction with the world is the consumption of television and radio and his interactions with Louise, the dying man's housekeeper. When the old man dies, Chance is forced to venture out into the real world where he gets lightly hit by the car of a dying American business mogul, Ben Rand. Sitting in the car is Ben's wife, Eve, who, when Chance introduces himself as “Chance, the gardener”, mishears his name as “Chauncey Gardiner”. Eve, not expecting Chance to explain his profession to her, only hears the information she asked for, while Chance is simply responding with what he believes to be his identity - an identity formed by the limited knowledge he has from television and his profession as a gardener. Miscommunication like this happens throughout the film and Chance ends up intriguing business moguls like Ben and even garners the attention of the President with his gardening knowledge being mistaken for commentary on the economy. It is helpful to look at David Wellbery's systems theory to explore how this miscommunication is manufactured for the characters in the film. Generally, Wellbery explains that different systems are constituted by the different ways people perceive, respond, and create meaning from their environments. Two categories of

systems Wellbry introduces are consciousness, a psychic system, and communication, a social system, both of which are closed off from interacting with one another without the language interface. While the audience recognizes the miscommunication happening in the film through dramatic irony, Chance, Eve, and Ben fail to recognize their miscommunication with one another because of their operation in different psychic systems and lack of understanding that language connects their psychic system to a social one.

The communication between Chance, Eve, and Ben during dinner reveals that none of them are operating in the same system. Note, I will be referring to the numbered script lines attached at the end of this essay (pages 7 and 8). In the attached scene, Ben, a businessman, questions Chance about his plans (line one) because he assumes that, based on the business suit Chance always wears despite his gardening job, Chance must be some sort of businessman. In line two, Chance, an out-of-work gardener, responds as truthfully as he can to the question that was posed. Next, in line three, Eve, a woman benefitting from Ben's fortune and enjoying living a glamorous life, sees Chance's request as an appreciation for beauty and a desire for leisurely activity because she believes, similarly to Ben, that Chance is an already busy and working man based on his appearance. In these first few lines of dialogue, we can see that Ben and Eve live in two similar yet different psychic systems: Ben operates in a business system and Eve operates under the assumption everyone lives in the same elite socioeconomic system that she does. While one may argue that Chance operates in a gardening psychic system, he doesn't at first believe that Ben and Eve are talking about gardening or that gardening is an integral part of their lives; instead, Chance operates in the social-communicative system by being present in the conversation, or simply "being there" like the title of the film suggests, and answering Eve and Ben's questions directly. The focus on gardening in his answers is a byproduct of his lack of

education and interaction with the real world. His operation in the system of communication means he creates an understanding of the specific information and responses given to him by Eve and Ben rather than reinforcing any preconceived notions he had of the situation and using those notions to evaluate Ben and Eve's language. We see examples of this in lines four, five, and six: if we look at Ben and Eve's lines disregarding the systems they are operating in, in line four, Ben conveys he doesn't have a knack for working in the garden and offers Chance a visit to the gardens with Eve to which Eve says she will not take him to visit the gardens at the moment. This information, in direct response to Chauncy's initial request in line two, to Chance means Ben is not able to work in his own garden and wants Chance to go to the garden in his place but Eve will not take him. This prompts Chance to declare that he is a good gardener to emphasize he can do the job Ben said he could not do and reassure Eve that it would be in the household's best interest to put him in the garden despite her denial to take him there. Eve and Ben's lines, lines four and five, take on completely different meanings when read in the context of their psychic systems - Ben doesn't like doing his business in the garden and Eve's life is bogged down with events socializing with Boston's elites.

A new question arises as this dialogue continues: even though they operate in different systems, how are the characters oblivious to their miscommunication when it's so clear to the audience? Commonly, miscommunication is coupled with confusion from the participants in a conversation, sometimes prompting a pause for clarification; but, even though none of them ever really understand the true meaning behind each other's words, Eve, Ben, and Chance's conversation ends at a playful and natural stopping point instead of confusion. Wellbery explains how the improbability of communication can be limited through redundancy: "Redundancy and constraint achieved through binary codes are modes of ensuring the continuity of systemic

operations despite the contingency of selections” (305). In line seven, Ben, while he doesn’t believe Chance is an actual gardener, uses the role of a gardener to express the role of a businessman. He is affirming Chance’s language, making Chance think his communication, his systemic operation, is being understood and deserves no clarification. Ben’s systemic operation in a business system is similarly affirmed in line eight when Chance vocalizes he understands Ben’s description of “the garden”, even though to Chance the garden is literal and to Ben, it is a metaphorical one. Although the garden means multiple things to the people in this scene, the redundancy of the specific language of “garden” lets both Ben and Chance believe they are referring to the garden that exists within their own systems. The characters don’t know how to use language to effectively express the systems they live in.

Arguably, the most flawed characteristic of Chance and Ben, which explains their susceptibility to miscommunication, is their failure to understand that language acts as an interface between psychic systems and the social system of communication. In lines eight, nine, and ten, Ben and Chance are essentially having completely separate conversations even though they are talking to each other. Chance attempts to explain that the only thing he can call his own after losing his job and his old home is the upstairs room given to him by Eve, but Ben appropriates his words to fit his own situation - the room upstairs is a metaphor for heaven after death. Wellbry claims that language is the medium that connects consciousness and communication and further explains: “language...enables communication to emerge as a reality sui generis despite the radical heterogeneity of conscious systems; it enables consciousness, we might say, to support communication” (304). While language has this power to connect Chance’s communicative system to Ben’s conscious system, Ben stubbornly remains in his psychic system by assuming Chance operates in the same system that he does; instead of attempting to

understand language, the words Chance speaks, as a connector between Chance's communicative system, the reason his answers are so direct, and Chance's psyche, Ben uses his words only to express feelings arising within his own psychic system: he believes heaven is referenced because he is close to his deathbed and doesn't believe a healthy man like Chance should give up on being a gardener, which he believes is a metaphor for businessman. To help us understand why Ben fails to process anything Chance says literally, Wellbery writes about how language can secure understanding: "language embodies the difference between "utterance" and "information" that must be "understood" if communication is to take place at all" (306).

Utterance refers to the act of speaking actual words and information refers to the context and meaning that those words convey. Effective communication in this scene would require an acknowledgment of this distinction between utterance and information from both parties: Chance needs to understand that uttering words, no matter how literally he means them, will not convey the message he wants because Ben has just met him and has no context as to who he is as a person. Chance's monotone voice further impoverishes his communication because it offers no leading inflection or tone for Ben to pick up on. Ben's shortcoming as a communicator is his reliance on only his system to supply him information; in other words, he believes that utterance and information are the same. He doesn't understand that utterance, the choice of words in a sentence, for example, can alter the information he preconceived to be relevant: if he acknowledged that Chance was just allowed to stay in his house and therefore could be living upstairs, "the room upstairs" could have been taken more literally instead of being interpreted as death, a context only relevant to himself at the dinner table.

While *Being There* revolves around a series of misunderstandings, the last line of the film makes clear to us what it wants the audience to understand: "Life is a state of mind".

Miscommunication explained through the lens of systems theory helps us understand that the way someone interacts and perceives the world is entirely dependent on the systems they occupy. Chance's ascent to international political power at the end of the film is comical to the audience because of the context we have: Chance is an uneducated, illiterate gardener that first stepped outside of his house as a middle-aged man. But, to the characters in the film, including a fictional president, their psychic systems inform their perceptions of Chance and they interpret Chance's words in a way that makes sense for the system they live in: essentially, they hear what they want to hear. While it is contentious to say that perception *is* reality, *Being There* leaves the audience seriously evaluating the power perception and one's own psychic system has on the way reality affects their lived experience.

RAND

1. So tell me, Chauncey, just what are your plans?

CHANCE

2. I would like to work in your garden.

EVE

(laughs)

3. Oh, I know exactly what you mean. I sometimes enjoy puttering around myself, such a pleasant way to forget one's troubles.

RAND

4. I never had a feel for it myself... But, Eve - why don't you show Chauncey our gardens tomorrow...

(to Chance)

They're quite lovely.

EVE

5. Well, it'll have to wait until I get back from Boston... Unfortunately, my morning will be taken up by another one of those charity events.

CHANCE

6. I am a very good gardener.

RAND

7. Isn't that what a businessman is?
A gardener? A person that makes
flinty soil productive with the
labor of his own hands, who waters
it with sweat from his own brow,
and who creates a place of value for
his family and community? Yes, in-
deed, Chauncey, a productive busi-
nessman is a laborer in his own
vineyard.

CHANCE

8. I know exactly what you mean, Ben.
The garden that I left was such a
place. But I don't have that any
more...

(points to ceiling)

...All that's left for me now is
the room upstairs.

RAND

9. Now, wait a minute, Chauncey - you
have your health... for
God's sake don't give up on your-
self! You have to fight!
You can't let those bastards
keep you down! I don't want
to hear any more from you about
the 'Room Upstairs.' That's
where I'm going soon.

There is a long pause. Chance looks up, then smiles at
Rand.

CHANCE

10. It's a very pleasant room, Ben.

RAND

(laughs)

11. Yes, I'm sure it is. That's
what they say, anyway.

Works Cited

Ashby, Hal, director. *Being There.* Warner Bros., 1979.

Wellbery, David, T., Mitchell W J, et al. "Systems." *Critical Terms for Media Studies*, The University of Chicago Press, Chicago, 2010, pp. 297–310.